

# COM 133 – Assignment one

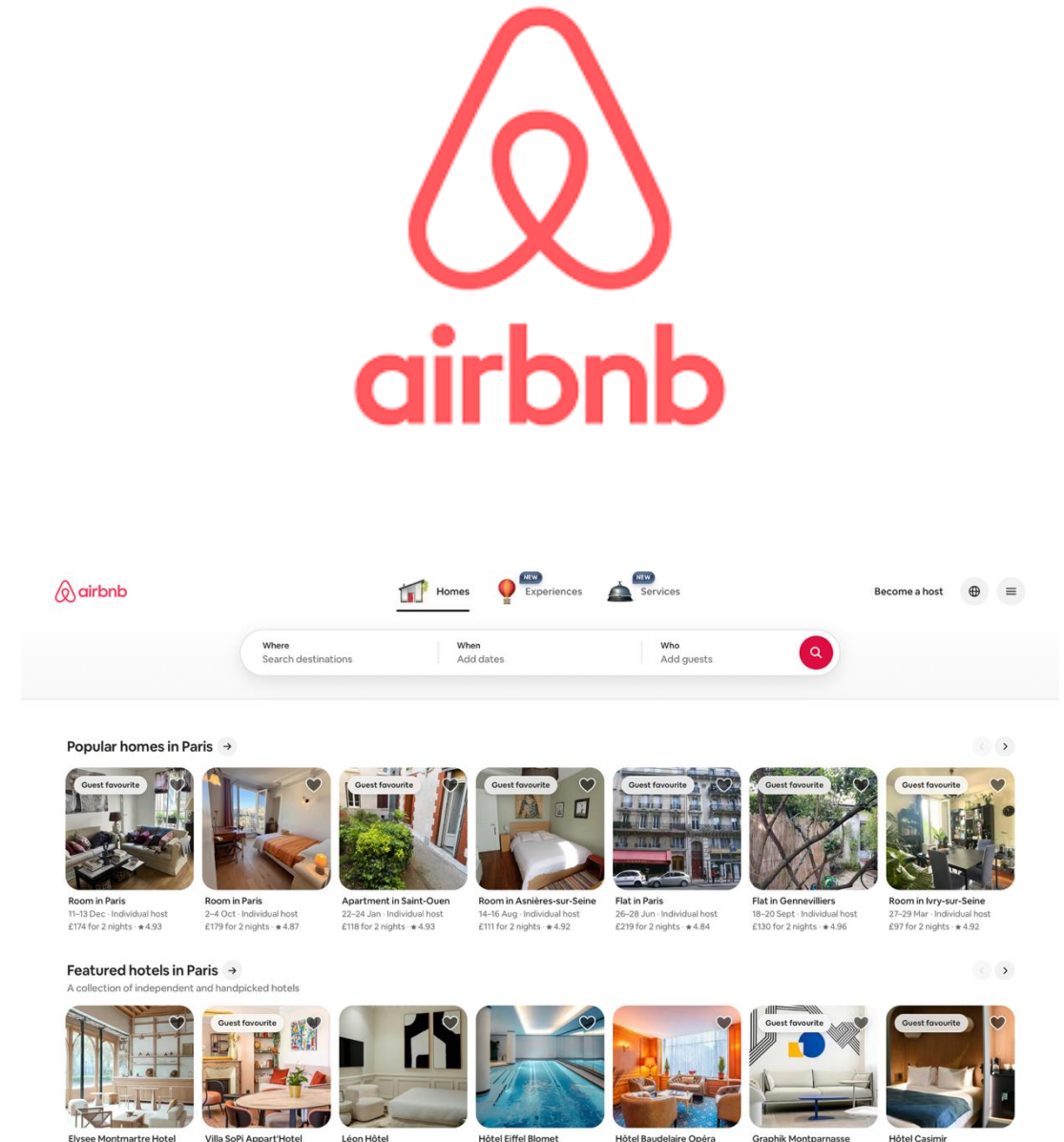
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B01021275 – Kaden Hunter

# Airbnb

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- I chose Airbnb as my website with a good UX perspective as the platform has a strong user-centred design, with an intuitive user interface making it simple and easy for its users. The platform supports its users to achieve their goals of finding and booking accommodation simply with minimal cognitive effort on the user. Airbnb has a great application of many HCI principles which I will discuss next.



# User-centred design and heuristics

- Airbnb follows Jakob Nielsens usability heuristics by providing users continuous system feedback during their booking processes, having and maintaining consistent interface layouts and supporting users' recognition through having features like recently viewed listings and wish lists making it easier for the user to navigate the site and reducing their memory load [1].

## Wishlists



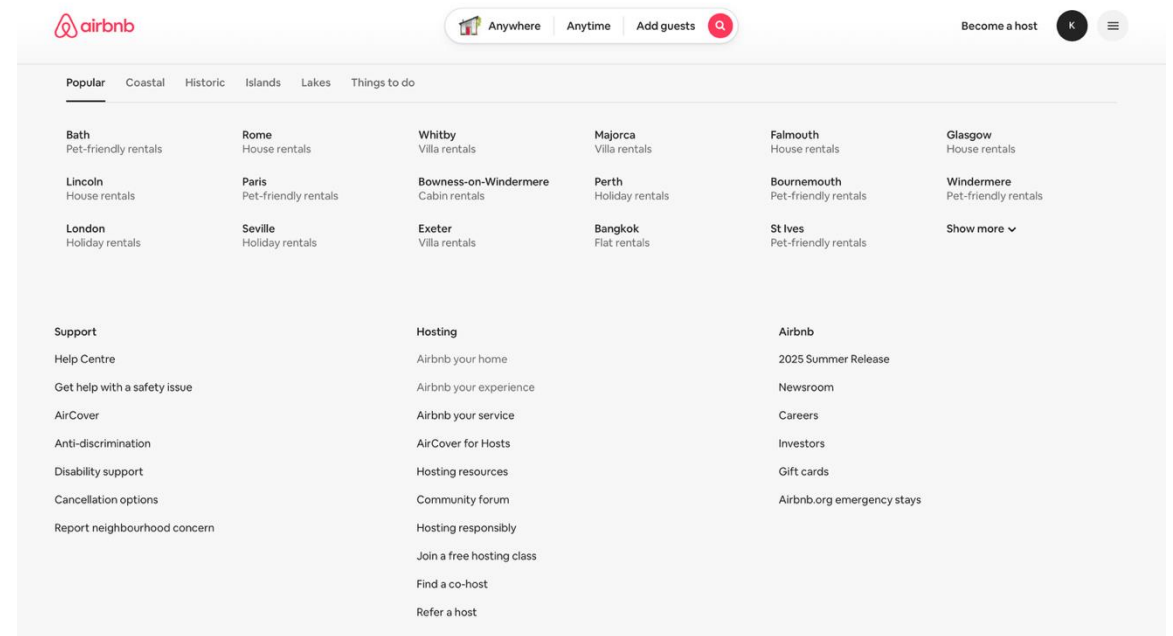
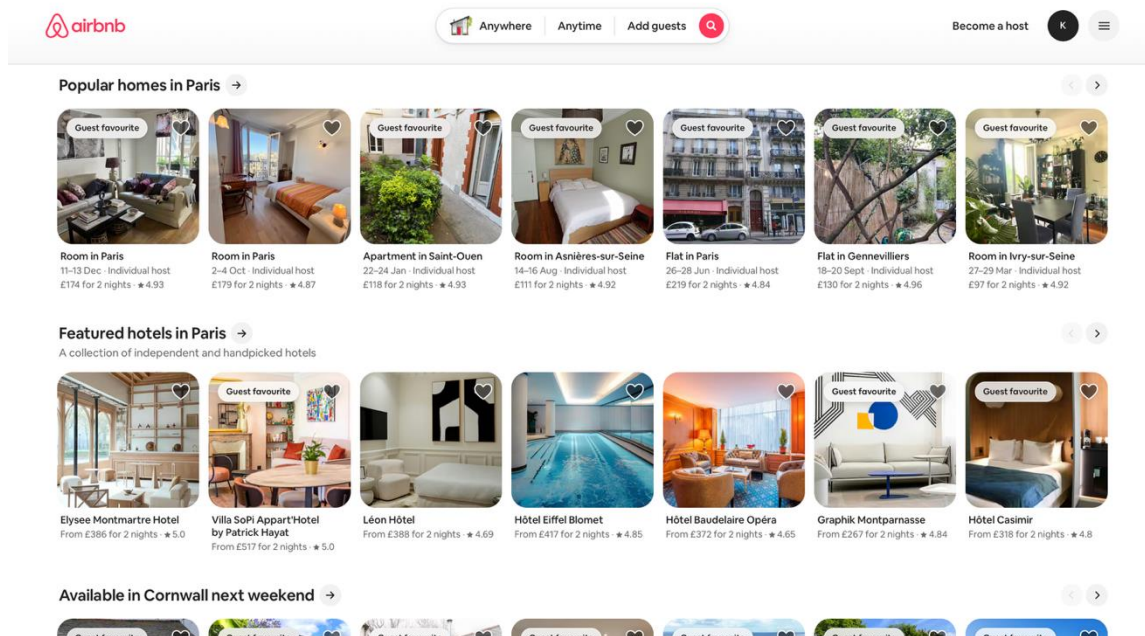
Recently viewed  
Yesterday



Wishlist  
1 saved

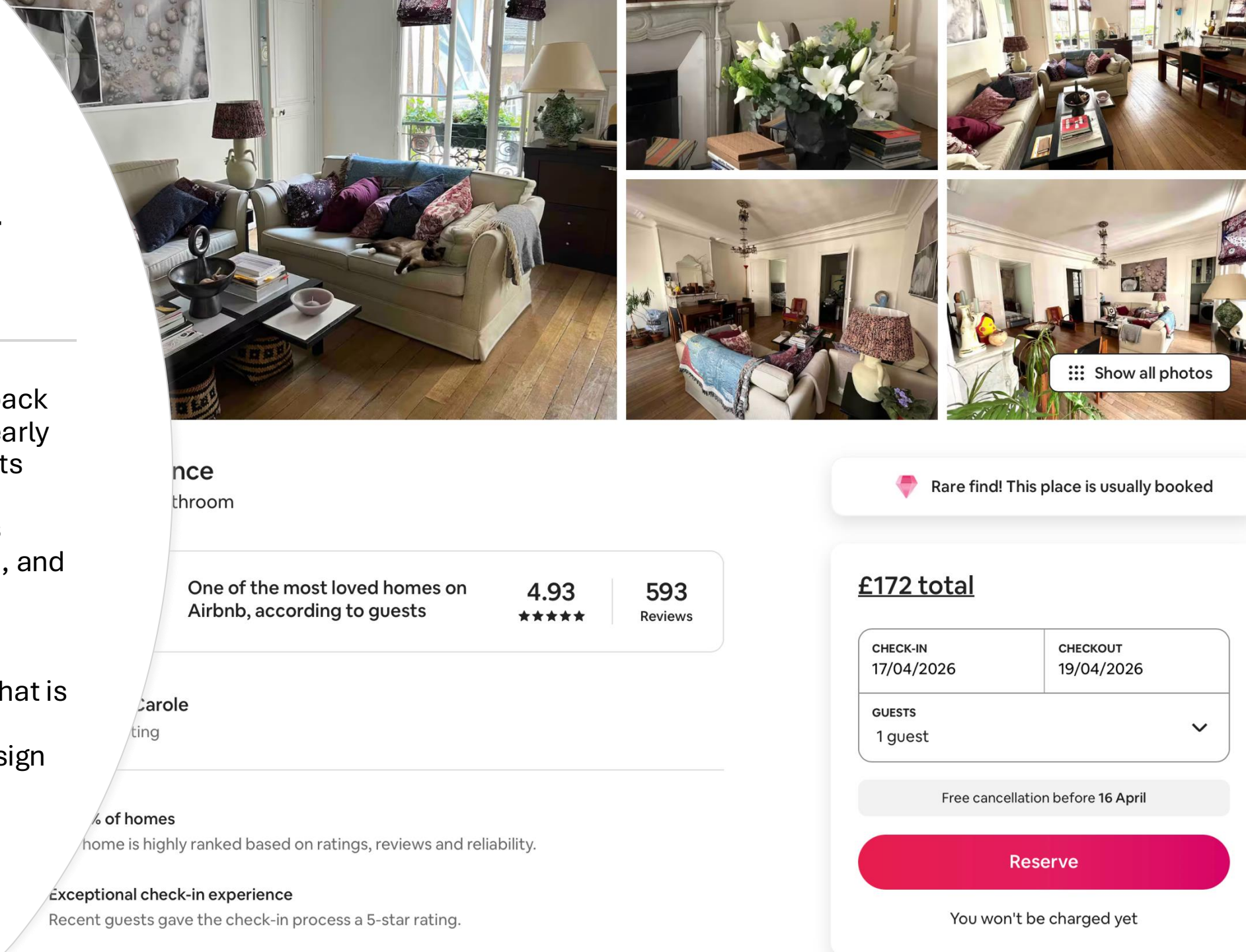
# Cognitive load and visual hierarchy

- Airbnb reduces cognitive load on its users by structuring more complex information into defined easy to see sections with additional content revealed as the user scrolls. This supports Sweller's cognitive load theory which puts emphasis on efficient information processing and minimalisation of cognitive effort in user interfaces [2]. There is also a strong visual hierarchy on the site where the most important primary information which is the accommodation to book is at the top and as you scroll down secondary information such as support, hosting and other tabs are shown at the bottom.



# Feedback and error prevention

- Airbnb provides clear feedback and affordances through clearly labelled interactive elements and real-time confirmation messages. The website has clear buttons, confirmation, and validation messages which helps users to understand actions and avoid making mistakes. This fits in with what is described by Norman's principles of interaction design [3].



nce  
throom

One of the most loved homes on  
Airbnb, according to guests

4.93  
★★★★★

593  
Reviews

Carole  
ting

% of homes  
home is highly ranked based on ratings, reviews and reliability.

Exceptional check-in experience  
Recent guests gave the check-in process a 5-star rating.

Rare find! This place is usually booked

**£172 total**

CHECK-IN  
17/04/2026

CHECKOUT  
19/04/2026

GUESTS  
1 guest



Free cancellation before 16 April

Reserve

You won't be charged yet

# Reviews and emotional design

- Airbnb's online reviews, ratings and transparent pricing reduces uncertainty and user errors as being able to see other users feedback on for example specific accommodation can help shape one's decisions.
- Airbnb also incorporates emotional design elements which enhance user trust and engagement. Research shows that having review systems, host profiles and the use of images contributes greatly to user satisfaction and confidence as they create memorable experiences which influence users to keep using the platform [4].

[Photos](#) [Amenities](#) [Reviews](#) [Location](#)

£172 total  
★ 4.93 · 593 reviews

Reserve



## 4.93

Guest favourite

This home is in the **top 5%** of eligible listings based on ratings, reviews and reliability

|                       |                                                                                     |                                                                                     |                                                                                     |                                                                                     |                                                                                     |                                                                                     |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Overall rating        | Cleanliness                                                                         | Accuracy                                                                            | Check-in                                                                            | Communication                                                                       | Location                                                                            | Value                                                                               |
| 5<br>4<br>3<br>2<br>1 | 4.9                                                                                 | 5.0                                                                                 | 4.9                                                                                 | 5.0                                                                                 | 5.0                                                                                 | 4.9                                                                                 |
|                       |  |  |  |  |  |  |

**Haoyu**  
11 years on Airbnb

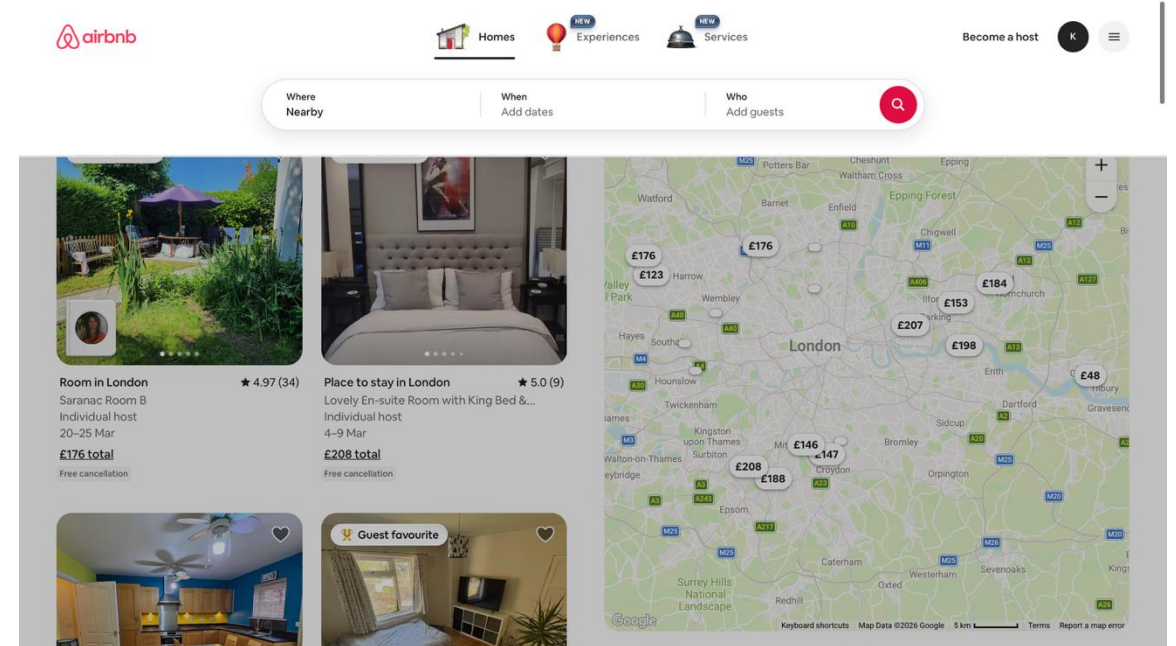
★★★★★ · January 2026 · Stayed a few nights  
Carole's apartment is a true Parisian home, full of life and enthusiasm. The location is perfect - Notre Dame is just a few meters away. I spent two wonderful nights in the very heart of Paris. Carole is very friendly, ...  
[Show more](#)

**Susanne**  
9 years on Airbnb

★★★★★ · December 2025 · Stayed one night  
I had a wonderful stay at Carole's apartment in Paris. The place is beautiful, tasteful, and filled with a very pleasant, calm atmosphere. The location is exceptional — just a stone's throw from Notre-Dame ...  
[Show more](#)

# Conclusion

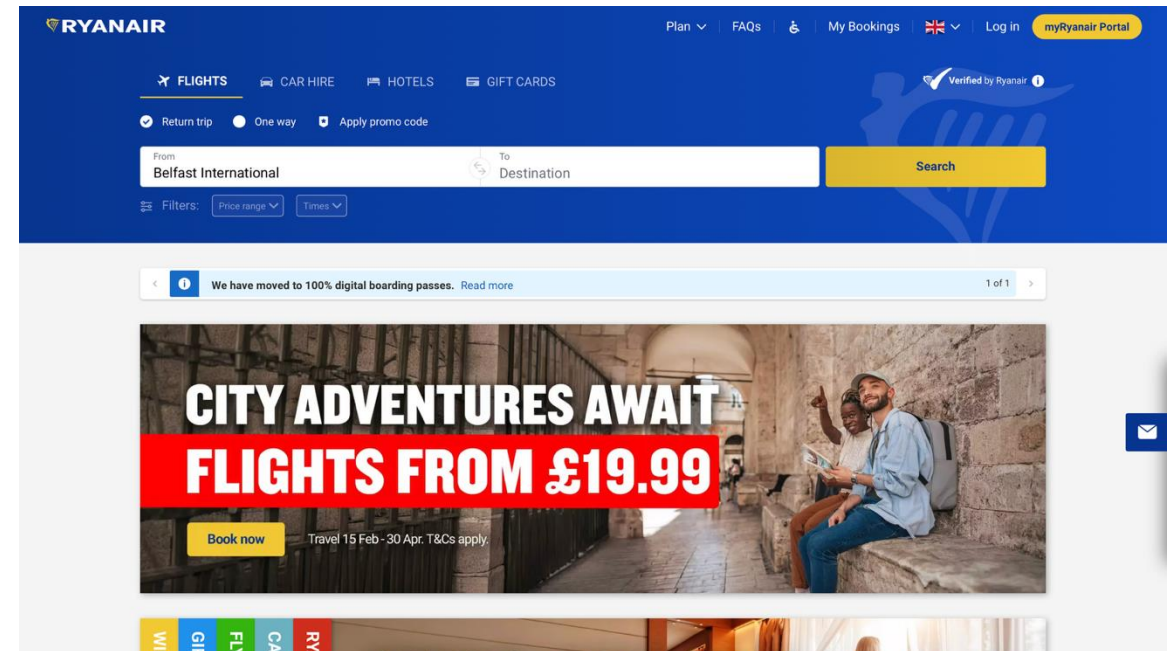
- Overall, Airbnb is a great example of good UX by providing great useability, cognitive efficiency and emotional engagement to create a smooth user experience.



# Ryanair

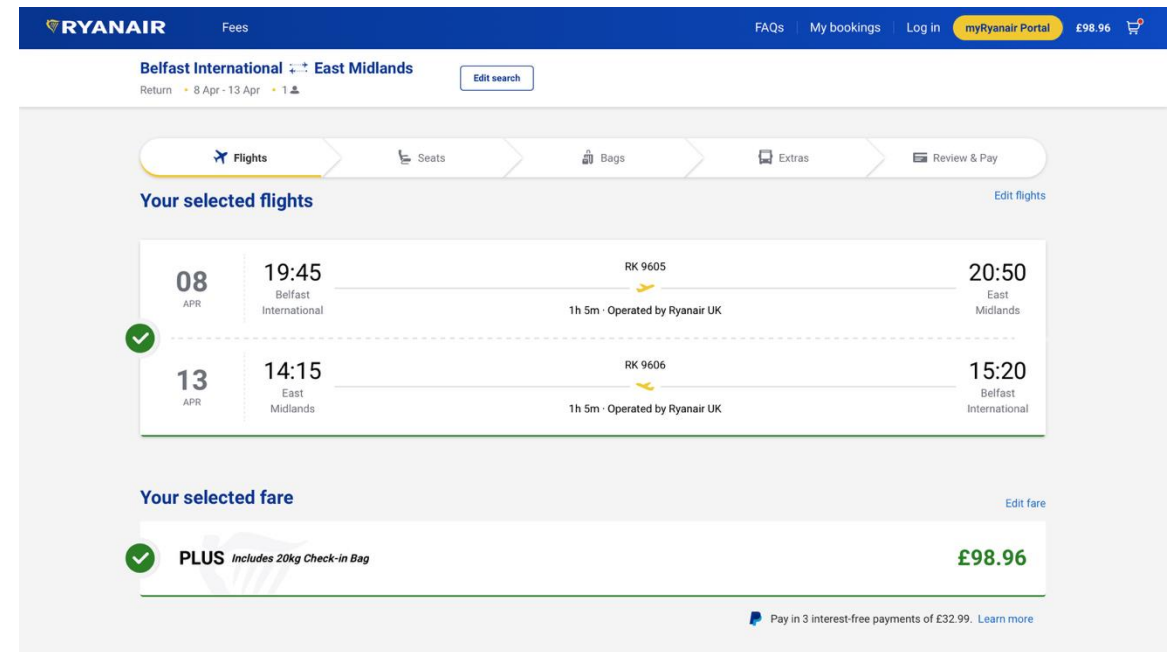
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- I chose Ryanair as my website with a poor UX perspective as although it is a very popular and commonly used airline service site its booking interface prioritises business and financial goals over having a user centred design. This causes increased. Cognitive load, reduced transparency and a higher chance of user errors during booking processes.



# Lack of human-centred design

- From a HCI perspective Ryanair fails to properly follow human centred design principles which are outlined in ISO 9241-210 which puts emphasis on designing websites and systems around user needs instead of organisational objectives [5]. Most users want to complete flight bookings quickly and efficiently, but Ryanair's website keeps interrupting the user's main goal by showing needed add-ons such as seat selection, insurance and bagging options. This blocks the user from their primary task.



# Cognitive load with overwhelming choices

- Ryanair's booking process also creates a large cognitive overload, at each stage of booking users are presented with large amounts of information, many forced decisions and many calls to action at the same time. Sweller's Cognitive load theory states that interfaces which introduce excessive unnecessary information reduces a user's ability to effectively process information and increases the likelihood of making errors [2]. This is a big difference to a good practice of UX design which aims to minimise unnecessary mental effort.

The screenshot displays the Ryanair website's booking interface. At the top, the Ryanair logo is on the left, and navigation links for 'Fees', 'FAQs', 'My bookings', 'Log in', 'myRyanair Portal', and a shopping cart with '£98.96' are on the right. The main header shows the route 'Belfast International' to 'East Midlands' with a return date of '8 Apr - 13 Apr' and '1' passenger. Below this is a progress bar with steps: 'Flights' (active), 'Seats', 'Bags', 'Extras', and 'Review & Pay'. The 'Your selected flights' section shows two flights: 08 APR from Belfast International at 19:45 to East Midlands at 20:50 (RK 9605) and 13 APR from East Midlands at 14:15 to Belfast International at 15:20 (RK 9606). Both flights are operated by Ryanair UK and last 1h 5m. The 'Your selected fare' section shows 'PLUS Includes 20kg Check-in Bag' for £98.96. At the bottom, there is a note about interest-free payments.

**RYANAIR** Fees [FAQs](#) [My bookings](#) [Log in](#) [myRyanair Portal](#) **£98.96**

**Belfast International** **East Midlands** [Edit search](#)  
Return 8 Apr - 13 Apr 1

[Flights](#) [Seats](#) [Bags](#) [Extras](#) [Review & Pay](#)

**Your selected flights** [Edit flights](#)

|           |                                   |                                           |                                   |
|-----------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| 08<br>APR | 19:45<br>Belfast<br>International | RK 9605<br>1h 5m · Operated by Ryanair UK | 20:50<br>East<br>Midlands         |
| 13<br>APR | 14:15<br>East<br>Midlands         | RK 9606<br>1h 5m · Operated by Ryanair UK | 15:20<br>Belfast<br>International |

**Your selected fare** [Edit fare](#)

**PLUS** Includes 20kg Check-in Bag **£98.96**

[Pay in 3 interest-free payments of £32.99. Learn more](#)

# Not following usability heuristics

- Ryanair does not follow several of Jakob Nielsen's usability heuristics, this includes error prevention, visibility of system status, and aesthetic and minimalist design [1]. The optional extras on bookings are often already pre-selected and opt-out mechanisms are unclear which makes it easy for users to make the mistake of accidentally purchasing a service they did not want.

## REGULAR is ideal for your trip!

Basic does not include a 10kg overhead locker bag, priority boarding or seat selection.  
Upgrade to Regular for only **£31.00 more** per person on each flight.

|                          | <br><b>BASIC</b><br><i>Travel light</i> | <b>Recommended</b><br><br><b>REGULAR</b><br><i>Choose your seat and 10kg bag on board</i> |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 small bag              | ✓                                                                                                                          | ✓                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Reserved seat            | ✗                                                                                                                          | ✓<br><i>Specific rows available</i>                                                                                                                                          |
| Priority boarding        | ✗                                                                                                                          | ✓                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 10kg overhead locker bag | ✗                                                                                                                          | ✓                                                                                                                                                                            |
|                          | <b>£129.83</b><br><small>Total price</small>                                                                               | <b>just £31.00 more</b><br><small>on each flight</small>                                                                                                                     |
|                          | <a href="#">Continue with Basic</a>                                                                                        | <a href="#">Switch to Regular</a>                                                                                                                                            |

# Dark patterns and price transparency

- Interactions such as these are known as “Dark patterns” which is a deceptive design method that manipulates users into decisions that benefit the organisation rather than the user [6]. Ryanair’s disclosure of fees and late price transparency further contributes to user frustration and uncertainty which has been shown to badly impact user trust in online booking services.

| Faro - Birmingham                      |             |
|----------------------------------------|-------------|
| 8 x Adult Fares                        | 919.92 GBP  |
| Sun 23 Sep - FR 3712                   |             |
| 8 x Plus                               | 240.56 GBP  |
| 60 day check-in                        |             |
| 8 x Reserved Seats                     | Included    |
| 08B, 08C, 08D, 08E, 08F, 09D, 09E, 09F |             |
| 8 x Check-in bags                      | Included    |
| 8 x 20kg                               |             |
| 8 x Priority boarding                  | Included    |
|                                        |             |
| Payment fee                            | 41.14 GBP   |
|                                        |             |
| Total                                  | 2098.10 GBP |

# Conclusion

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- Overall, Ryanair shows a poor example of UX due to increasing cognitive load, reducing transparency and using manipulative interaction patterns. Comparing this to Airbnb which supports their user's goals through trust and understanding. Ryanair shows how neglecting UX and HCI principles can end up frustrating users and causing an error prone experience.



# References

- [1] J. Nielsen, “10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design,” *Nielsen Norman Group*, 1995. [Online]. Available: <https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/>
- [2] J. Sweller, “Cognitive Load Theory,” *Psychology of Learning and Motivation*, vol. 55, pp. 37–76, 2011. <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-12-387691-1.00002-8>
- [3] D. A. Norman, *The Design of Everyday Things*, Rev. ed. New York, NY, USA: Basic Books, 2013. [https://www.google.co.uk/books/edition/The\\_Design\\_of\\_Everyday\\_Things/I1o4DgAAQBAJ?hl=en&gbpv=0](https://www.google.co.uk/books/edition/The_Design_of_Everyday_Things/I1o4DgAAQBAJ?hl=en&gbpv=0)
- [4] S. Li, K. K. F. So, and S. Hudson, “Customer responses to the Airbnb platform: The role of Airbnb experience and memorability,” *Int. J. Contemp. Hosp. Manag.*, vol. 34, no. 8, pp. 2925–2945, 2022. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJCHM-07-2022-0821>
- [5] International Organization for Standardization, *ISO 9241-210: Ergonomics of Human-System Interaction—Human-Centred Design for Interactive Systems*. Geneva, Switzerland: ISO, 2019. <https://www.iso.org/standard/77520.html>
- [6] C. M. Gray, Y. Kou, B. Battles, J. Hoggatt, and A. L. Toombs, “The dark (patterns) side of UX design,” in *Proc. CHI Conf. Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 2018. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3173574.3174108>